# PoliticsQ3: Is Democracy in Crisis?

## Introduction

Democracy itself is not in crisis; if anything, it has become too successful, so successful that the old machinery of representative government can no longer bear the immediate appearance of the people.[1]

The question “Is democracy in crisis?” changes meaning depending on who asks it. For elites, it names the failure of old mediating institutions; for citizens, the gap between expression and power; for political theory, the possible failure of the people’s power to judge power.[2]

This essay argues in four steps. First, today’s democratic decline shows a crisis in representative machinery, not the failure of popular sovereignty itself. Second, popular sovereignty must depend on mediation because the people cannot govern the modern state as a permanently assembled body. Third, mediation always risks becoming possession: parties, courts, media, and electoral rules can reshape the conditions under which the people later judge power. Fourth, today’s nation-state, party system, and attention economy make the people appear faster while making stable judgment harder to form. Therefore, democracy is not dying as a principle; it is struggling with the machinery required to realize itself.

### I. Why It Looks Like Crisis but Is Actually Success

The mainstream crisis thesis has factual grounds; populism, polarization, and strongman politics are rising, and global democracy indicators are declining. V-Dem records a sharp global democratic decline in its 2026 report.[3] Freedom House similarly records a long decline in political rights and civil liberties worldwide.[4] Hungary and Turkey show the country-level pressure behind those figures.[5]

These facts are enough to prove that many democracies are under pressure, and enough to prove that the old representative machinery’s capacity to process the people’s voice is declining. But they cannot directly prove that the democratic principle has failed. The crisis of any particular democracy depends heavily on its local context; one cannot directly elevate democratic countries are under pressure into democracy itself is in crisis.[6] The people still judge power in the language of democracy, and power must still answer in the name of the people.

Three levels must be distinguished: the democratic principle, the representative machinery that translates that principle, and actual democratic capacity. Shared facts, elections, parties, media, local self-government etc. belong to the second and third levels. Their decline shows a crisis of democratic realization, not the failure of the democratic principle itself.[7]

Some may reach a similar conclusion through a narrower procedural definition: as long as competitive elections remain, and as long as the people can periodically remove a government, democracy has not entered crisis. This answer is close to the conclusion of this essay, but its reasoning is insufficient. For elections to constitute genuine authorization, they must depend on the premise that a future majority can still overturn today's majority.[8] If these conditions disappear, voting remains, but it is no longer revocable authorization. Therefore, this essay is not denying crisis by using a minimal electoral standard; it is distinguishing the democratic principle from the representative machinery that realizes that principle.

All these phenomena presuppose the absolute victory of the democratic principle. The problem is not the principle, but the machine.

## II. Why Popular Sovereignty Must Depend on Mediation

Democracy's success first appears in the fact that popular sovereignty has become a principle of legitimacy that modern power cannot bypass. Locke places the beginning of the political community on consent: people form a community through consent, and the majority decides how it acts.[9] This means that the first principle of modern democracy is that no one is naturally qualified to rule others; public power must derive its legitimacy from authorization by the people.

But this does not mean that the people must first prove that they are forever wise or correct. The foundation of democracy is that no one can prove a natural right to rule the people. To cancel the people's political qualification on the grounds that they may not be rational enough is to presuppose a judge standing outside the people. The people have political qualification because they bear political consequences; whoever bears the consequences cannot be excluded from judgment. Therefore, populism, misjudgment, or mass emotion may show that democratic mediation needs correction, but they cannot prove that the principle of popular sovereignty has failed.

Yet the people being the source of legitimacy does not mean that the people can continuously govern the modern state directly. Modern governance is complex and specialized, while the collective judgment of the people can only appear intermittently.[10]

The fact that the people are not a naturally unified rational subject is precisely the basis on which mechanisms of correction must operate. Representative democracy must rely on local self-government and associational life to train scattered individuals into public actors.[11] Democracy cannot assume that this continuous capacity will automatically exist; it must depend on a set of institutional conditions that can themselves be judged by the people, so that dispersed expression in the present can be transformed into common judgment across time.

## III. How Mediation Turns from Transmitting the People into Possessing the People

In modern representative government, the people's authorization is intermittent, while the machinery of governance is continuous. Once consent is given, it is no longer merely a ballot. It is immediately embedded in an institutional structure with inertia of its own, and one capable of self-reinforcement.[12] The consent-givers, namely the people, cannot be present at every moment to control every specific application. When the people say, I consent to your representing me, that sentence, from the moment it is spoken, has already partly separated from the people who spoke it.

Thus democracy's success immediately generates an institutional difficulty: the people are increasingly qualified to appear, while the agency machine is increasingly able to deposit that authorization into its own structural advantage. Since institutional structures can reinforce themselves, they acquire the capacity to change the conditions of future consent. The people consenting to government does not mean that government owns the people, or that a representative may possess authorization. If agents change the conditions of subsequent authorization through constitutions, courts, media, and electoral rules, then the old representative machinery is no longer merely transmitting the people's judgment; it begins to shape the boundaries of the people's future judgment. This means that democracy must carry out the current majority's agreement, but it must also preserve the possibility that a future majority can overturn today's majority.

The contradiction within democracy lies exactly: when these organizations and mechanisms are captured by narrative or agency structures, the people can still appear immediately, yet the old representative machinery finds it increasingly hard to transform that appearance into continuous self-government. At this point, the crisis is not that the democratic principle has disappeared; it is that the mediating institutions meant to transmit the people have begun to possess the people.

## IV. Why Today's Old Representative Machinery Cannot Bear the Immediate Appearance of the People

This section shows why today's representative machinery struggles to carry popular sovereignty. Two mechanisms matter most: the struggle to define who counts as "the people," and the attention economy's ability to turn political pain into circulation without turning it into judgment.

### 1. Who Can Define the People

Modern representative democracy once relied on the nation-state to integrate dispersed populations into a representable *people*.[13] Through a common language, national education, and other means, representative government could generate the claim that it represented a political community. However, globalization, migration, and class have weakened this premise.[14] The *people* no longer merely disagree in opinion; they increasingly suspect whether the other side belongs to the same political community at all.

American party realignment shows this fracture. Political conflict increasingly separates voters not only by policy preference, but by education, class experience, and cultural identity.[15] It still retains coalitions of racial minorities and the public sector.[16] Trump-style Republicanism is better able to summon non-college-educated voters, small-town voters, and ordinary people who feel forgotten.[17] This feeling is experienced not simply as policy preference but as moral displacement.[18] The old axis of the left equals worker redistribution, the right equals capital tax cuts has been disrupted. Economic pain still exists, but it is more easily translated into claims about immigration, religion even cultural identity.[19] When shared conditions weaken, elections no longer stably perform the function of collective decision-making, and more easily become a zero-sum struggle among fragments.

The more successful popular sovereignty becomes, the more easily the name of the people is contested. Power cannot openly say that it opposes the people, stands above the people, or that the people have no right to judge; all powers must package their own power as the will of the people.[20]

Hungary shows this form: Orban does not need to abandon democratic language. He only needs to construct Brussels, migration, and George Soros as external threats in order to push opponents outside the boundary of the people, and then use the name of the people to remake the conditions of later authorization.[21] The 2022 OSCE election report describes the election as well run but lacking a level playing field.[22]

Someone might say: Orban destroys democracy with democratic language; is that not exactly democracy's crisis? Here one must distinguish the success of the democratic principle from the satisfaction of democratic outcomes. The more effective method for Orban-style politics does not need to openly deny popular sovereignty; but to monopolize

the definition of the *real people*. What he does is hijack the representative machinery, not abolish the democratic principle. If this monopoly ultimately makes it impossible for opposition to organize and for the people to withdraw authorization, then that particular regime may of course die.[23] But the cause of its death is precisely that the representative machine has blocked the people's power of judgment and betrayed the democratic principle; it is not that the principle of popular sovereignty itself has become invalid.

### 2. The People Appear Faster but Find It Harder to Form Judgment

Second, the attention economy further changes the political function of expression.[24] The function of democratic tools such as traditional parties is to translate local pain into public issues so that those issues can be institutionalized and handled. But platforms and the attention economy allow pain to become traffic, emotional circulation, and friend-enemy narrative directly.[25] The United States shows exactly this mechanism. The problem is that even though private pain spreads faster, it is harder to organize into continuous judgment. Platforms have not silenced the people; platforms make the people appear faster, and process that appearance into emotional units fit for circulation.[26]

Many ordinary Americans are not first persuaded by complex policy; they first feel, in his image, that they are noticed and represented in a retaliatory way. Old mediating institutions failed to translate their pain steadily into policy; new media and performative politics rapidly translate that pain into identity and anger.

The result is that the people can be summoned more and more easily in the instant; yet expression can appear instantly, while public judgment still requires slow time to form; the old representative machinery finds it increasingly difficult to transform such summoning into continuous self-government.

## Conclusion

Democracy is not in crisis at the level of its principle. Popular sovereignty remains the highest standard by which power must justify itself; even strongmen must rule in the people's name. But democracy is in crisis at the level of representative machinery and democratic capacity. Parties, parliaments, media, electoral rules, local associations, and platforms increasingly struggle to transform dispersed expression into continuous, revocable, and correctable judgment.

Therefore, democracy is not in a crisis of principle. A crisis of mechanism is not a contradiction that can be eliminated once and for all, but democracy's permanent task. The health of democracy lies in keeping its mediating institutions always subject to the people's judgment and replacement. Democracy has no completed state; it is a political form that continuously prevents the people from being possessed by those who represent them.

## Endnotes & Reference


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